there have been any complaints regarding forcible conversions or conversions by allurement or fraud. In the past four years, there have been 14 FIRs in connection with disputes among villagers for following or not following rituals and traditions. A total of 158 people are being tried in connection with these incidents. What is happening, therefore, is that the more recent converts to Christianity are not reporting or applying for a change of religion, but disputes are arising at the time of birth, death or marriage as converts and non-converts within the same family opt for rituals based on their religious persuasion.

The larger debate centres around whether the converts were tribals or Hindus before converting to Christianity. "The tribals are, of course, Hindus," says Judeo. "They are the keepers of the purest form of Hinduism." Christian leaders and a section of the tribals themselves deny any such simplistic notion, pointing to the traditional Sarna religion of the tribals over a vast swathe. A section of tribals has been demanding that they will not list themselves as Hindu in the next census, something that worries the BJP given

MAHARASHTRA

THE DALIT OUTREACH

By Dhaval Kulkarni



Desperate times, they say, call for desperate measures. With the upcoming civic elections becoming a prestige fight and deemed the penultimate battle before the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, the two rival Shiv Sena factions are outdoing each other to woo Dalit groups.

So, the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) faction is working on an alliance with Prakash Ambedkar, chief of the Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi (VBA) and grandson of Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar, while the breakaway Balasahebanchi Shiv Sena (BSS) under Chief Minister Eknath Shinde has tied up with the Peoples Republican Party (PRP) led by former Lok Sabha MP Jogendra Kawade. The BJP, the senior ally of the BSS, is already in an alliance with Ramdas Athawale, who leads his own faction of the Republican Party of India (RPI), and is a minister of state in the Narendra Modi government.

It is easy to see why mainstream political parties are on an overdrive to woo the RPI factions and, by extension, the neo-Buddhist Dalits. The neo-Buddhists (erstwhile Mahars who converted to Buddhism with Ambedkar in 1956) comprise 7-8 per cent of the state's population and are the largest group among the Dalits. Also seen as the most militant section among Dalits, they're easy to mobilise around issues. Maharashtra has around 59 Scheduled Caste (SC) groups. Though no community votes as a monolithic bloc, the various RPI groups enjoy support among the neo-Buddhist Dalits.

On November 20, Uddhav and Prakash had shared the dais at an event to relaunch a portal on the works of 'Prabodhankar' Keshav Sitaram Thackeray, who was among the foremost social reformers of Maharashtra. Prabodhankar was Uddhav's grandfather and one of the prime proponents of pro-Bahujan (non-Brahmin) Hindutva. He was also an associate of Dr Ambedkar.

This meeting between the two grandsons set the ball rolling for an alliance for the civic polls in cities like Mumbai, Thane, Pune and Nagpur.

The overture to Prakash is but natural. Unlike other RPI leaders, his base cuts across sections like Hindu Dalits, Alutedars (smaller OBCs), Muslims as well as educated and urban Dalits. In the '90s, Prakash stitched a rainbow coalition at Kinvat in Nanded and developed a base in the demographically-diverse Akola district in Vidarbha, which he has represented twice in the Lok Sabha (1998 and 1999). He also commands a following in districts like Akola, Washim, Buldhana and has pockets of support in Mumbai too.

On January 4, Shinde and Kawade too announced an alliance between their parties. In 1984, the maverick Kawade had joined hands with alleged smuggler Haji Mastan Mirza to form the Dalit Muslim Suraksha Mahasangh in the first such Dalit-Muslim political equation in Maharashtra. Kawade has also been in an alliance with the Congress and Nationalist Congress Party.

The two Senas led by Uddhav and Shinde are locked in a battle to affirm their credentials as the "real" Shiv Sena. This depends on their performance at the hustings, especially in Mumbai, where the BSS-BJP combine is trying to wrest the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC), the richest civic body in India, from Uddhav's rump Sena. When the fight goes down to the wire, the support of these smaller parties and fronts can help tilt the scales.

Incidentally, the Sena and the Buddhist Dalits have a history of animosity. The Sena and the Dalit Panthers clashed at Worli in 1974; the Panthers were seen as the only social force capable of